Zhen Lu: 00:00
Hi, Zhen, how's it going? Good to see you all again. Actually, I didn't ask this time, but what is lino? Is that a person or is it a bot?

Emmett Chen-Ran: 00:09
It is a bot. It is our AI co worker that we build.

Zhen Lu: 00:13
Ah, I see. Okay. I figured that might have been the case, but I was like, I. I don't want to. There's a name on it. And I was like, if it's a person that just doesn't have camera, like.

Millie Hanson: 00:23
You'Re thinking.

Zhen Lu: 00:28
That'S funny.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 00:28
Realistic.

Zhen Lu: 00:30
We'll have to trade notes on the. The AI co worker thing at some point. But.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 00:36
Yeah, I just wanted to, you know, provide some. Some technical support if needed. But overall, Millie will be running the content interview and she is a brilliant interviewer. And so you're in very capable hands. But I'll just be here.

Zhen Lu: 00:48
All right, no worries.

Millie Hanson: 00:50
Amazing. Lovely to finally meet you and actually chat this time. I'm just gonna.

Zhen Lu: 00:56
Yeah. I don't think you much last time. So glad.

Millie Hanson: 01:00

Yeah. On the first, sort of. Cool. I'm more of like an observer and in there I'm just thinking how I'm going to strategize and execute and I've got some great ideas kind of for your content. So I'm super excited for this content interview and see what we can like, definitely whip up. No, I won't let you ramble. I will be. I'll be like, Zhen, stop. We've got to go to the next question, so don't worry. But also, we love a bit of a ramble, especially kind of on the first. On the first sort of content interview. But just for your understanding, this content interview, we'll have these kind of once every, say, month or bi weekly. And what this basically means is that we can get enough content and it's from you, which is a source of truth. And just flesh out these posts for the month.

Zhen Lu: 01:49
Sure.

Millie Hanson: 01:50
So don't filter anything or second. Second question yourself. And if there's anything that is super technical or I might be like, Zhen, can you simplify it a little bit? You're more technical than 90% of us on LinkedIn. So we just want to make sure that in your content we can communicate it in a way that the broader audience will really understand.

Zhen Lu: 02:13
Okay. One thing that I might ask, actually, and Dan, you keep me honest here. What we were talking a little bit about in a conversation that we were having is kind of just efficient use of time. Right. I'm having these types of conversations, I think, with quite a few parties now, and since we're going to be doing this more regularly, I'm wondering if we can think about having you distill out some of the themes so that we could share with other people. Either internal to run pod that might actually benefit from getting the distilled out themes so that I might not need to have like multiple of these types of meetings in order to share some of these thoughts. Just, just kind of thinking out loud.

Millie Hanson: 03:03
Yeah, of course.

Dan Stotts: 03:04
Expecting this makes sense.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 03:07
Are you able to share who the other parties are? And so we might be able to like tailor the conversation here. Like would you rather us be the, the meeting and then it goes to other people or would you rather you have the meeting with someone else and we just take the transcript or something?

Dan Stotts: 03:20
But I can route the questions, you know, and try to minimize the exposure from Zhen standpoint, no problem.

Zhen Lu: 03:34
Yeah. And I don't think it has to be like this source of truth or anything. I think one thing that I'm just trying to understand is how best I can like amplify right. Some of the things that you know, I'm thinking about and saying. Right. And so I'm, I am trying to write like internal memos and things like that. But even having a, just more of like a way to internally share. Right. I'm assuming you're going to try to dig some interesting thoughts out of me. You know, being able to just have that somewhere for other people to perhaps read or use might be useful. But let's, let's focus on, let's focus on, you know, what you all are good at first before I didn't let you get very far before I derailed. So I apologize. Please, please go ahead.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 04:20
Okay, yeah, I'm just gonna say real quick, we have like a meeting note taker like that you can download like granola if you want to just have our note taker on while you're having these other meetings with people so we.

Zhen Lu: 04:30
Don'T have to need, we don't need.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 04:31
To have this interview if you're running our note taker in your other conversations.

Zhen Lu: 04:35
Gotcha. No, I mean, I think like I'd rather like this is, this is the only like Cadence meeting that I'm aware of right now. I think it makes most sense for us to try to, you know, milk as much as we can from this for sure.

Millie Hanson: 04:50
I mean that's up to us. We can definitely get a lot of, a lot of content out here. It might just be like a couple of follow up questions, but again, I'm sure you're going to help us get all the golden stories. So I'm going to jump into it. Before we do, have you got any questions?

Zhen Lu: 05:07
No, I'll. I'll let you do your thing.

Millie Hanson: 05:11
All good? Amazing. So we really want to start with kind of people on the platform don't really know who you are yet on LinkedIn, and what we're trying to do is kind of say, hi, I'm Zhen, and really paint a picture. So what I'm wanting from you here is are you able to walk me through your career journey, when you first got interested in startups and when kind of to now when you first started running kind of run pods, say from age 17? I'd love you to just walk through that.

Zhen Lu: 05:42
Age 17. Oh, my God. What the hell was I doing? You want me to ramble or you want me to try to tell it in a more like, concise manner?

Millie Hanson: 05:51
In a more concise manner, but if you start to ramble, I'll catch you and put you back on course.

Zhen Lu: 05:56
All right, gotcha. All right, so when I was 17. Yeah. All right, let me. How personal versus, like, professional?

Millie Hanson: 06:08
Let's go with, say, where you're at school and then what you were studying and then kind of any challenges you had along the way or any competitions you won. Just a real kind of way to highlight, say, each age what you achieved or lesson learned. Got it.

Zhen Lu: 06:24
All right. Yeah. I would say the. The major thing that I learned when I was 17 was that I was a very shy person. And I was done being a shy person. So when I was in high school, I was like, more. I played a ton of video games. I was like, ready to kind of maybe go pro, but I knew my parents would kill me and so I didn't do that. So then I was like, all right, well, I'm just gonna do what my parents kind of want me to do. Went to University of Pittsburgh for college. I actually started like, a lot of people start in pre med because, you know, Asian parents. I actually really liked chemistry. So I ended up switching to chemistry to do my degree because I just thought the. The work was super interesting. Specifically, actually, I really loved my. My physical chemistry professor. I think I really respected this guy because he was the kind of professor that would like, he wrote his own book and he taught like, very non traditionally. And, you know, that really spoke to me. And quantum chemistry was just super interesting because it was like crap

that you really couldn't wrap your head around. Math, right? Lots of abstract thinking. And so. So I ended up actually pursuing that for My graduate career as well.

Millie Hanson: 07:54
And sorry to butt in, but how old are you at this age?

Zhen Lu: 07:59
Like 22.

Millie Hanson: 08:01
22. So I just need to go. So we got 17. 18 is when you went to university?

Zhen Lu: 08:10
Yeah.

Millie Hanson: 08:12
Then 19.

Zhen Lu: 08:16
I think. 19. I went through like a lot of personal, like re. Redefinition, I guess, because I mentioned 17, like one of the shyest kids. Didn't really put myself out there at 19. I was like, all right, I'm gonna put myself into. Like, I like took drama courses and like, you know, did improv and just did. Did all sorts of shit that I would never have done like the year prior because I was like, I'm in college, right? So did a bunch of stuff like that. Dyed my hair red, did all the stuff that I didn't feel like I could do when I was home. But you know, honestly, college, college was pretty. It was rough, right, because I did have a very. I still had a great passion for like video gaming. I was a big StarCraft 1 player. Played, you know, semi professionally. I didn't win any awards or anything like that, but I was like quite good. And that made it to like the. A lot of the students around me. I think, like my cohort of freshman students, I think the attrition rate was like 50% first year because most people couldn't handle like the, the academics plus like all the other stuff that was going on, you know, whether that was, you know, parties, whether that was video games. Like there's just all this stuff, right. That you had like unlocked freedom on, you know. So I just, I just navigated that for. For the next several years. I would say, you know, college was college. I wasn't like a rock star student or anything like that, but, you know, made it through and I think learned some life lessons, that kind of stuff. So I think we can fast forward maybe through that stuff.

Millie Hanson: 10:22

Yeah, for sure. And then kind of from when you left college to Runpod. Can you run me through a little bit of what you got. Got up to between then?

Zhen Lu: 10:31
Yeah. So graduate school was a big one. Got a PhD also in physical chemistry. So, you know, that was really cool because I got to dig deep in some of the things that I really just scratched the surface on in my college days. Really loved it because it was. So I joined Spiritual ma's lab at Temple University.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 10:55
She.

Zhen Lu: 10:56
She was doing research and you know, this. It will get. It'll be a little bit technical, but it's electronic structure theory on DNA base pairs. So it was all about kind of the ideas, you Our DNA is really good at dissipating energy, right? So if you think about it, you, like, spend time in the sun, you get bombarded with a lot of energy. And, you know, there's. We're like, why, why don't people get skin cancer more? And there are like, chemical reasons for that that are not well understood. And your DNA base pairs, because of the way that they're structured, are actually really good at mysteriously, like, basically wiggling out energy rather than reacting and mutating. And so I did research along this line with her. It was super great because I was, I was doing. It was math, biology, chemistry, and physics. So I took physics courses, I took a bunch of math courses. So it was really good from, like, an academic and like, mind point of view and also just like from a perseverance point of view because I, you know, now that I've been through a PhD, I'm like, you don't have to be that smart to get a PhD. You just need to, like, tough it out. And I'm not sure if I was smart for toughing it out or dumb for toughing it out. But anyways, you know, like, I spent the time there, learned a lot about how to learn, which something that I think has stuck with me. After I graduated, I did take a professorship job for two years, so really enjoy teaching mentorship, that kind of stuff, but it was like, really damn slow. And then like after about two years, I'm like, this is, this is too slow for me. I love students, I love mentorship. But, you know, none of this research is really going to see the light of day. I don't make very much money. I don't get to choose, like, where I live. Literally, job opportunities are like, waiting for people to die because they don't retire. And I was like, yeah, you know, probably not the life that I want to stay in long term, though.

Millie Hanson: 12:59
Were you the youngest person there?

Zhen Lu: 13:01
Pretty close too? Yeah. And it didn't help that I, like, definitely looked like the youngest person there by like, a lot. So. So yeah, I ended up actually quitting that job cold turkey during a summer vacation. Taught myself kind of, or at least try to teach myself like, what, what it is to be a software developer and then just got went for jobs. So that's. That gets me to 2017, I think 2017. Most of my time, you know, between age 17 and when 2017 hit was kind of in like the Pa ish area. So, you know, my high school days were like central pa, like bumble fuck nowhere. That's just where my. My parents were living at the time. And then I went to college. Right. Pittsburgh, so west a little bit, and then graduate school at Temple. So Philadelphia area. And, you know, I've been mostly in the Philadelphia area since then. Got the job at Comcast because there was a new team there and they wanted to take a chance on me. And that's where I met my co founder, Pardeep. So we worked together for six years, did a lot of distributed systems in the cloud and built really good rapport with him. So the great thing about Pardeep is.

Millie Hanson: 14:41
I will say again, sorry, I'm just going to butt in here. I will get onto that side of the story just to make sure that we're really getting the right content out of you, because mine is a nice little segue into the next question I have for you, actually, as well as kind of the story you've had up until now. I just want to talk kind of about the early days. So can you walk me through the early days of Run Pod? And kind of my first question to that is, because there's a whole narrative to that is what inspired you to really start to start Run pod?

Zhen Lu: 15:15
Yeah. So a few, I think, different ingredients. Right. So number one was I, you know, I don't think I'm the traditional, like, serial entrepreneur, right. Like, I'm fairly entrepreneurial, but I have never been the person that's like, what's the next company I'm going to start? Right. Who am I going to start it with? Like, I'm always itching to do that. Pardeep, right, is that kind of person. And so I would say one of the definite, like, catalysts for runpod is definitely that I met somebody that I felt really good about being my co founder, Hardeep is a serial entrepreneur. And I didn't know, like, to what extent until actually after we started RunPod. But before that, right? Like for the. Over the course of probably four of the six years.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 16:14
Right.

Zhen Lu: 16:14

So fairly early on, yeah, Pardeep and I had built enough of a rapport together and, you know, we were kind of like, we should totally start a company together at some point.

Millie Hanson: 16:24
Would you be able to walk me through kind of that moment where you realized that, like, you guys wanted to go into partnership together?

Zhen Lu: 16:33
I'm not sure if there was like a. If I remember like a this is the day, but I can tell you why. Right? Like why? Logically, we kind of got there and it was because, like, Pardeep and I share a lot of the same like, values and philosophy specifically, kind of that we. We really value trajectory more than we value, like, raw years of experience, for example. Right? So, like, in our professional lives, that's why he took a chance on me, because he was like, oh, you know, maybe this person doesn't know all of the book answers, but it's very clear that they are thoughtful about how they approach things and that they can learn and they really, really want to do this. Right? So he on me to hire me onto the team. And then pretty early on, like, within a year, I was like, y' all suck at hiring. Like, I went to my boss, and I'm like, we suck at hiring, and if we want to be a successful team, like, we need to get better at it. Like, I can't promise you that I will be perfect, but I'll make it a lot better than it is today. Like, are you.

Millie Hanson: 17:47
Would.

Zhen Lu: 17:47
Would you be willing to give me the chance? And she's like, please. Because we were just not hiring the right people. And I was like, we're like a super small, young team. We were like, you know, eight. Eight to 10 people at the time, and we needed to grow. And so I took over hiring pretty early on, and I think that was kind of like the start of, like, a party. Like, oh, yeah, you know, like, this person is not only good as a technologist, but they've got other skills to bring to the table.

Millie Hanson: 18:19
Okay, sorry, just to butt in, just understanding, you joined kind of as a team member, and then later on, kind of, you went to be a founder. Am I right?

Zhen Lu: 18:34
This was at Comcast. So, yeah, I was. I was an ic.

Millie Hanson: 18:37

I'm with you now. Sorry.

Zhen Lu: 18:39
Yeah, you're good. So this was at Comcast. I was an ic. And so that's where Pardeep and I were just really building the rapport. Because your question was around, like, when did you decide that you would be a good founding team? And I think that was a major part of it. Right? Because I was also, at the same time, proving to Pardeep that I could be his peer from a technologist perspective. Now, I will always admit to anybody that Pardeep is a better engineer than I am. He is, like, a really amazing intuition engineer where it's, like, not fair how fast he can pick up new technologies and just, like, tell people how it should be done when those people have been doing it a lot longer than he has. So he's not perfect, Right. But he's got really, really solid intuition, and he can make things happen. And so, like, there's the overlap, right? It's like we, we have the technologist overlap where we have a lot of mutual respect for one another. But I'm always going to tell people that he's a better engineer than I am and he's always going to tell people that, like, I'm a better manager than he is. Right? And so we're like, you know, that that's basically a perfect two person founding team. So then what do we do? And so we like kick around ideas and it's probably like two, three years in knowing each other, or like, we should totally do something at some point. It was just a matter of what. And I think the other ingredients that came together were, number one, we were building these really cool things, like in the cloud. And it was like, all right, well, wouldn't it be really freaking awesome if we would, you know, we were building the cloud, but, you know, that wasn't really on the table. So then, you know, when we get more into GPUs and alternative accelerators and different types of workloads, we're like, hey, there might be something here, right? This could be a wedge for us to be able to build a cloud rather than be builders in a cloud. And we had conviction that it was just a matter of time. And so we said, well, we're software developers, let's just go write the software, otherwise we're going to miss the bus again. We'd rather be early than late. And it just turns out that it was a really, really freaking good time because we were neither really early or really late.

Millie Hanson: 20:47
You got on the bus at the right time.

Zhen Lu: 20:49
Yeah, exactly.

Millie Hanson: 20:52
Okay, so you, that's what inspired you to kind of start it. And then how did you come up with the name Run Pod out of story around this?

Zhen Lu: 21:05
No, no, I mean, we were literally, we had built the entire software platform without naming it. And we're like, we should really not fall into the trap of trying to make this thing perfect before we launch it. So we're like, all right, we're going to launch it by the end of this month. And we're like, okay, what needs to be true for us to be able to launch it by the end of this month? And we're like, oh, shit, we need a name and we need the domains and we can't deploy this thing without a name. So, all right, how are we going to name this thing? And so I think we set like a deadline. We're going to have a name by the end of this week and we're just Going to, like, spitball things, and we're just going to disagree and commit if we have to. And we went through not a huge amount of names, but it was really annoying because we come up with a name, we're like, oh, that sounds pretty good. And then we do the research on is that domain taken? And so many domains taken, or it's already a thing. And. And finally we're like, okay, well, we're running things and their containers. So, like, run pod. And I'm like, I don't even remember who came up with it. It was me or Pardeep. And we're like, all right, good enough. And then we got like. Our original icon was like, you know, a Creative Commons, like, you know, whatever, generated just clip art, basically. Logo. We just needed something to launch the damn thing. And so the DLDR there is. We came up with a name because we needed a name, and it is what it is.

Millie Hanson: 22:45
You need to send us the first version of your logo.

Zhen Lu: 22:49
Oh, my God. So it's like a little box, like a cartoon. I can send it to you. And we actually ran into trouble with this because there was actually a scam somebody was running where they were sending people a masked link to our checkout page. And since our logo looked like it could be like a courier service, they were just sending emails to people with logo to their checkout page on our website saying, have a delivery that you need to put in money for to complete the delivery or something. And people were doing this, and I'm like, oh, my God, we got to make this better somehow. So, yeah, the original logo is just a box.

Millie Hanson: 23:37
Then that's when you scrap the logo and realize you had to upgrade.

Zhen Lu: 23:41
No, actually, we scrapped the logo just because we were doing. We wanted to have a logo that was ours. So we just did a little bit of a rebranding exercise and decided to

redo the logo. So we ended up with a logo that is actually spiritually similar to the original logo, but we designed it, and it feels more like an evolution of the logo rather than complete replacement.

Millie Hanson: 24:10
Okay, cool. I would love to matter away to you, but I just want to make sure that I get every point and I need for the content. So my next question is, what were the first few critical hires you made and what were these roles?

Zhen Lu: 24:25
Yeah, okay, that's a little bit of some drama there. Ish. So I would say that the one most critical hire that we made early on was actually Luke Piet. When I hired him, Luke was maybe 20. He might have been 19. 19, 20. Years old. I got connected to him actually. Don't even know how I met Luke. I don't even remember he was in sf. I was on the East Coast. Like I don't actually remember how I met Luke. Probably a. Some kind of network in production. But I hired Luke as head of Growth because he was like well connected in sf. I'm like, you're, you're a sharp dude. Like you'll figure things out and we just need somebody that is going to grind with us.

Millie Hanson: 25:21
Why was that role, the first role you wanted to hire for?

Zhen Lu: 25:25
It wasn't the first role that we hired for. I think when we hired Luke we were like eight, nine people, something like that. The first roles we actually hired for were engineering roles because you know, we're engineers and we need frickin help to build more stuff faster. But I would say that like, you know, from, from like a just raw like impact perspective, like I'm not going to say that, you know and most of those engineers that we hired early on are still with us and they, they're continuing to actually do really well. But like from an impact perspective like Luke was, was huge because he made, he made introductions to Silicon Valley Network, VCs, et cetera. That I still am leveraging today, those connections incredibly important. And that setting aside just Luke's superpower to just plow through and figure out things.

Millie Hanson: 26:31
Yeah, I guess. Is Luke still with you now?

Zhen Lu: 26:34
Yeah, he's still with us.

Millie Hanson: 26:36
No, we should definitely do a little highlight post at some point and just explain, explain like how Luke has impacted the company. We're seeing like a lot of content like that perform well on LinkedIn to just really show what happens behind the curtain essentially and the people that are kind of paving the way for these businesses. No, shout out to Luke.

Zhen Lu: 26:59
Yeah, you know, there were other hires that we made that were I think differing levels of impactful. Like we did hire pretty early on some people like from our community to help with like support because I was running solo. Support plus developing plus you know, you know, wearing all the hats. Right. And you know, a lot of times, you know, like I was at like my son's birthday party and I'm like, you know, handling a support ticket and getting shit from my wife. So.

Millie Hanson: 27:30
Okay, cool. This next bucket we're going to go into again a little bit of a storytelling but it's around like these small decisions that made a huge impact. So the little choices, so the funny or surprising moments that reveal really the culture of the company or how you think as a Founder. So what I'd love to hear. Could you tell me about a recent dinner or meeting with a customer, investor or founder where something small surprised you or, or taught you a lesson? There's quite a lot there. So we can break it down with a recent dinner with a customer, let's say.

Zhen Lu: 28:21
You know, because we're distributed. Like, I don't get as much kind of in person, you know, contact like that as anyone, like.

Millie Hanson: 28:32
Or a phone call, if that was. If that's easier.

Zhen Lu: 28:37
Yeah, I mean, I, I would say that like, you know, I, I recently was on a call with the, the CTO of one, actually. No, coo. COO of one of our successful customers, Glam Glam Labs. Right. So they, we have a case study on them and it was, you know, it's always amazing to kind of hear what kind of milestones the companies that are building on us have hit. So like they just blew past 16 million ARR, 60. And I'm like, you all haven't even raised like a formal round yet. Yeah. And like having this person be like, yo, you know, we rely on runpod. Like there are customers like these that say company wouldn't exist without runpod. Right. And like, so that's like incredibly amazing to hear from your,

from your customer. And then, you know, just like, hey, you know, I'm asking them, like, how do we make things better for you? Right? Like, what kind of things would you like to see on the roadmap and being able to talk kind of founder to founder, right. At that level where both of us know, right, what's going on rather than, you know, I think maybe you'll, maybe I'll get to the point where, you know, like if you talk founder to founder, you know, it's so high level now, right. Like, you don't have as much like direct impact on things, but I'm really enjoying kind of being at where I'm now, where I'm able to do that. So I think that that's maybe one I do have.

Millie Hanson: 30:17
Sorry, Are you happy for me to call him out in a post potentially, or would you prefer for me to keep that anonymous?

Zhen Lu: 30:26
I think, I mean, we can ask permission, but I, you know, we have them as a public case study.

Millie Hanson: 30:31
Okay.

Zhen Lu: 30:32
I don't think it would be, you know, remiss. They'd probably enjoy having the call out for sure.

Millie Hanson: 30:40
And then any else, like top of mind that you can think of that would be, that would be good to shout out.

Zhen Lu: 30:49
Yeah. So I would say one of the things that really helped Us, especially, like, when we started, but even now is the really amazing kind of founder community, and this is in Silicon Valley, but also outside of Silicon Valley, of just founders that are willing to be generous with their time and help somebody like me that doesn't have any experience and honestly didn't really have anything to offer. So, like, one really meaningful thing that I still remember was. And I think I maybe had told this story to a reporter or something, but, like, Julian Chaman, right? CTO Hugging Face. The way I met this guy was he went back when we still had, like, live website chat. The guy was like, hey, you know, on live website chat, I use your product. I think it's really awesome. Like, we should talk sometime. And at the time, I didn't know who it was.

Dan Stotts: 31:45
I was like, awesome.

Zhen Lu: 31:47
Like, I just saw that it's a Hugging Face domain. I'm like, I'll talk to somebody from Hugging Face. That sounds cool. And, like, so we scheduled a call, and then I'm like, all right, I should probably do some diligence on, like, who this person actually is. I look him up. I'm like, it's a freaking cto. Like, what? You know, I'm like, no one, right? And it's just. It always, like, surprised me, you know, how just cool people were in wanting to just talk to people. Like, that hadn't really made it right. Like, they had no reason to necessarily give their advice or time, but they did. And, you know, that. That repeated multiple times. So, like, actually when I mentioned Luke, a founder that he introduced me to, that who really helped us out was Marco Mascoro, who's now a partner at a 16Z. But at the time, he was still running his company, a AI robotics company. And, you know, and just being able to meet founders that I've been able to, like, keep in touch with, ask for advice, anything from, like, hey, you know, how much should I pay my leaders? How should I build a leadership team? How can I keep company culture from eroding, right? Like, how do I hire people that are better than me? Like, you know every question, right? I'm able to have somebody that will just have, like, a real talk conversation with me that has been there, done that, and that's been incredibly helpful, for sure.

Millie Hanson: 33:19
You mentioned, obviously, CTO of Hugging Face said, were they using your platform or what was the conversation around?

Zhen Lu: 33:28
Yeah, yeah, Julian, it was a personal user of RunPod, and he was like, edge wanted to let you know that it was awesome product. Use it like other people on my team. Use it Just wanted to say hi. It was a very casual conversation.

Millie Hanson: 33:40
Did you ever jump on a call or was that literally.

Zhen Lu: 33:42
It jumped on the call and he ended up putting an angel check in the company.

Millie Hanson: 33:50
And that was on the back of a little pop up message.

Zhen Lu: 33:53

Yeah, literally. I was like, okay, yeah. It's funny, like one of our board members, Radhika Malik, who's Deltec Capital, the way I met her was she sent me a random Reddit message. This was like a year before we raised money.

Millie Hanson: 34:07
Yeah.

Zhen Lu: 34:08
And she was like, hey, you know, VC would love to talk. I'm like, oh, never talked to a VC before. She's the first VC I ever talked to. And it was cool because, like, there was like no stakes. And she was like, hey, you know, here are the things that you might want to be thinking about. Like, so she was actually offering feedback and value before, like we did anything.

Millie Hanson: 34:30
Yeah, for sure. I think that's like one thing I've definitely established is a lot of people are willing to give up their time and actually speak to you. And I think as well, if you're a genuine nice person and you've got a lot to say, people are willing to just carve out their time to spend a bit of time with you. But yeah, no, they're super interesting. So especially the Reddit one, I think what would be great as a follow up, I'll speak with Melissa and see if we can just get a couple of these screenshots because what you've given me there, you've given me already. I've got kind of little ideas for content and being like, ah, Reddit or a little chatbot message. So there's all these little pieces of content that we can get out. But I'm going to go on to the next question now and this is more like around your team to get these little golden nugget stories. Following on from what you said earlier, has there been a small decision you made recently that your team questioned or didn't really understand?

Zhen Lu: 35:31
Hmm, small decision.

Millie Hanson: 35:35
It could be big. Whatever you want to feed me.

Zhen Lu: 35:42
I think more recently we've been pretty aligned. Yeah, I guess I wouldn't go so far as to say they didn't understand it, but like, you know, I'll call Dan out. Right? So Dan hasn't been in seat for, for very long and when we hired him, we wanted to make sure that he understood that he would have support. Right, he would have support because we felt that marketing was something that we were pretty honestly shit at. And we hired him to

make Us better, right? And so we have this weekly leadership staff meeting and one of our agenda items is to go through kind of hiring job requests. And so, you know, not that long after Dan joined, he put in quite a lot of marketing team hiring requests. And I, I didn't approve any of them.

Millie Hanson: 36:48
I can just see Dan smiling in the corner.

Zhen Lu: 36:51
And then, you know, I can imagine because I didn't communicate like, you know, like directly prior to or anything. And Dan wasn't reporting me directly. He reports to Justin, our CEO. But still like, I can imagine Dan was sitting there thinking like, dude, you hired me. You're not going let me hire, you know, hire anybody else. And you know, and Justin was also like, you know, you got to give this guy some, some hires. I'm like, you know, just, just, just humor me. This is not me like roadblocking. This is not because I don't want to hire these people. It's because I have committed to myself and the company to take responsibility for kind of how we hire and who we hire. And so I just want to make sure that, you know, this is not like a month thing. It's like, let's just take an hour and make sure that I understand what we're doing so that, you know, then I can have like, okay, I've done my diligence. We can responsibly go out and form these teams because I think it's pretty easy once you've raised money and we will continue to raise money. We have a lot of, relatively a lot of resources to put to bear and it'll be really easy for us to kind of go off the rails for sure.

Millie Hanson: 38:05
No, it makes complete sense. Hopefully I'll see a big team soon.

Zhen Lu: 38:10
I'm terrified. But it'll be fun.

Millie Hanson: 38:13
We'll be seeing Run Pod everywhere and you'll know your work is done. We're going to go into the next part of it again, very much story driven style. But now we're going into the relationship you have with your co founder, which always does well on LinkedIn, especially kind of with you guys. I did see kind of your TechCrunch article. So just kind of on the back of that, I've got a couple of questions, but can you tell me a time about when you and your co founder disagreed? What happened and how did you resolve it?

Zhen Lu: 38:53

Huh. You know, Part of, I don't disagree very much. Let me. I guess, you know, there are some times when party doesn't necessarily agree with like decisions that are made from like an org structure, perspective. Because Pardeep is very much cut of the cloth of, let's go. Like, very, very strong bias for action. Very, very. Has a strong appetite for risk. And so he's like, very much the. We have to drive innovation. Okay. To break things. Let's go. We need to go. And I temper that, right. With kind of more intentional thoughtfulness of action. And so, like, we try to balance each other that way, and I think we do generally do a pretty good job. But, like, you know, very early on, you know, we were in a. I think we were actually opening the bank account, and the banker was like, all right, so you actually, like, need titles, like, who's the CEO? And that was actually not a big discussion. I was like, all right, somebody needs to be CEO. Like, party. Like, what do you think? He's like, it's all you, man. Like, you want you to try it. I'm like, all right, I'll be the CEO. Like, so it wasn't like, a huge, like, intentional discussion, but, you know, in hindsight, it was probably the right call because he. He doesn't really want to manage people. But what he's been really good about is he. He will give me, Right. His counsel and his kind of advice, and he will defer to, like, the decision that I make because he knows, like, my ass is on the line for it.

Millie Hanson: 41:03
Yeah.

Zhen Lu: 41:04
And so, like, so I think we have a really good rapport that way, where I'm like, if this really matters, like, let's hash it out. But we just hash it out and we make a decision, and we're both good with it. So I think, like, some of the. Some of the, like, specific ones are like, you know, if we want to hire a key hire. Right. Sometimes he's of the opinion that, like, maybe we don't need to hire an executive. We can just, you know, make do with what we have. Like, we can just hire somebody, and they'll figure it out. And sometimes we've done that, and sometimes that we. We've hired somebody like Dan. Right. Who, like, he has been there, done that, and he will help us mature the company. And so sometimes those kinds of discussions have been had and we don't disagree on them a lot, but I think he generally leans more towards, let's just do it.

Millie Hanson: 41:56
Yeah. Can you walk me through kind of that scenario where you agreed to hire Dan just so I get, like, a full understanding and can kind of flesh out that narrative a little bit more?

Zhen Lu: 42:09
I'm not sure if party was like, don't hire Dan.

Millie Hanson: 42:13
But if the agreement that you, you came to hire Dan.

Zhen Lu: 42:19
I was like, like, okay, you know, like we, we need, we need, the conversation is like, we need to do marketing better. And like, nobody's going to disagree with that. And he's like, all right, well, like we have people under marketing, right?

Millie Hanson: 42:32
Yeah.

Zhen Lu: 42:33
Can't we just, you know, give them more resources, money, whatever, Right. And tell them to do better or whatever? I'm like, no. I was like, I don't think that's really how it's going to work. He's like, well, he doesn't like the philosophy of like, we need to hire somebody to be able to do something.

Millie Hanson: 42:51
Yeah.

Zhen Lu: 42:52
Because he's like, you're, you got to hire to like solve your problems. If you don't know how to solve your problems, like, you're not going to be able to, you know, silver bullet, hire somebody to solve your problems. Which I do agree with. But I think there are some times where it's just like, we have to move faster. Right. And sure, you know, we can get smart people to try to reinvent the wheel, but there are times where it's like, hey, we just need to bring somebody on. And I think the, you know, actually coming, coming back to Luke, I think one of the things that really gave me confidence that we absolutely needed to make this higher was that Luke was head of growth for a while. Right. And he was basically like leading marketing without necessarily knowing how to lead marketing. And Luke being somebody that's very self aware is like, yo, you, you, you need to hire me. Somebody that is going to be able to 10x or 100x me. Right. Like, I need somebody to mentor me and to help me out. I don't care about my title. Right. Like, I do not care if you need to demote me or whatever. And I think like that kind of conversation gave us both conviction that like, we, we needed to get on this.

Millie Hanson: 44:03
Yeah, no, that makes complete sense. I feel like I need to meet Luke. He sounds like a hero.

Zhen Lu: 44:10
That's great.

Dan Stotts: 44:11
Okay.

Millie Hanson: 44:14
Okay. Amazing. And then what's something unique about how you and your co founder work together? I know you touched upon this a little bit earlier, but I just love to note a little bit.

Zhen Lu: 44:24
Yeah. You know, it's, it's something that's weird, right? Because I don't know how other founder relationships go. It's, it's, it's a double edged sword because one of the things that I think is special about Pardeep and me is that we, we have a lot of natural Alignment not only from a values perspective, but also from like a, a technical developer intuition perspective. We share a lot of the same like, development tenets and philosophies. And so when I think back to when we were developing runpod, we're both technical founders, we both wrote code. It was very natural for us to divvy up the work and just go. And we don't have to talk about it that much. It was literally like you could imagine maybe like some founders are like in the same room day after day, week after week, like you know, really hammering on something. There were times when I didn't have to talk to Pardeep about like what we were programming for days because he knew what he had to get done, I knew what I had to get done. Like once in a while I'd be like, pardeep, I need your opinion on this. Once in a while he'd be like, Zhen, am I, you know, am I, am I going crazy here and get together, hash it out and then like we would go back back. So like we had like natural communication where we didn't have to talk. Right. To, to, to be on the same page. And the reason I say that's a double edged sword is because as you hire more people, you can't expect them to operate like that, even though it's incredibly efficient. And so we needed to like really just explicitly say, like, okay, well, not everybody operates like this. We're not going to be able to scale a company like this. So we do need to build better communication in the way that we run this company.

Millie Hanson: 46:20
For sure. It very much seems like a divide and conquer sort of situation. Yeah, for sure.

Zhen Lu: 46:27

You know, I think some people divide and conquer and then they like second guess themselves like each other. Right. It's like, oh, you know, that was your thing, but you did it wrong. Like you should have done it like this. And we had like zero of that.

Millie Hanson: 46:36
Yeah. You guys trust each other.

Zhen Lu: 46:39
Yeah.

Millie Hanson: 46:40
I love this. This is more of a question, a curious piece. And I think a lot of people will also be curious to kind of what happens behind your business. Like you said, like, marketing is something that you're really like hammering on this year. So we, we kind of want to talk about your engineering culture. So, so what do you think is the unique thing about your engineering culture.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 47:11
Hard?

Zhen Lu: 47:11
You know, that's a hard question to answer because I have not seen enough engineering teams to like know what the baseline is. Right. What I can say is that I have very high confidence that our engineers like the, the bar of talent for engineers in run pod is incredibly high. Yeah. We have really, really talented folks and it's a very diverse group.

Millie Hanson: 47:42
Okay.

Zhen Lu: 47:45
See what else? I mean, we've got a really great engineering leader. One thing that I didn't say, and like, this is something that, Please, we have to coordinate maybe how. How to write about this, but I think actually a really good thing to write about around this is that Pardeep started as CTO of the company because he was, you know, the more technical person. Yeah, right. And recently in just January, we did the title change for him to become chief architect and we promoted our head of engineering to cto. And that is, you know, that that's huge. I think not only from a. Obviously the titles change and everything, but kind of shows like how self aware Pardeep is and how low ego he is. Because that is not a. That's not an easy transition to make. Right. So, like, that's

something that I have a lot of respect for. Party like to just be able to graciously do that. And it's like, it honestly, like, doesn't even matter to him.

Millie Hanson: 48:57
No.

Zhen Lu: 48:59
But I don't think I could say the same for a lot of other people. So Brennan, who is now internally. We haven't announced it externally or anything like that, so we'll have to figure out timing if we're. If we were going to do that and tell that story. He is an amazing individual and he has really built something special. In terms of engineering culture, I would say that we have pretty flat engineering structure. We have management, but it's quite light right now. It's kind of more like teams that are kind of run by staff engineers. So that's going to be changing as we evolve the engineering team over the course of this year. But it's just so, I guess it's so interesting to see like, so many talented people coming together to build something that honestly, like, if you think about like our entire engineering team, this like, covers sre everything. It's like 30 people and we're building a functional cloud at scale. And it's like, it's like ridiculous how much responsibility, like each individual person has. There are companies that like entire companies of 30 engineers building what would count as like a feature right. In our product. And this is the challenge, right? Because once in a while I turn to Brennan, I'm like, yo, this small feature that we just scoped out is like an entire company. Like.

Millie Hanson: 50:40
When did. So is Brennan, like one of the first kind of engineers that joined the team back in the day.

Zhen Lu: 50:45
No, actually, Brennan was a random opportunity hire back to this kind of like, have I had dinners with people that have been super impactful. Yeah. I was at a random dinner in New York. I was invited by a founder friend for, like, no good reason. And I just showed up and it was like this really awesome venue. They had these giant speakers. It was like, there's another impactful hire that I could talk about. But it was like a really low key, very intimate dinner. And I just happened to meet Doug Suttles, who founder and previous CEO of the company Ookla, and just struck up a conversation with this guy. He was super nice and he was like, hey, what can I help you with? Right? Because he had just exited Ookla and he was just generally wanting to help. And I said, well, talent, like, I really need to hire some really good talent. We had just raised money, right? And I was like, you know, who are the best people that you've got that might want to join us at runpod? And he was like, let me think about that. I think you should really talk to

Brennan, who is our CTO now. And he said, you know, Brennan is like, I think he was VP of Eng at Ookla, but he's like, this guy is incredibly amazing and he could be a cto, right? In, like, a lot of companies. I'm like, well, I'm not looking for a cto. I already have a cto. And he can just have the conversation even if he doesn't join the cto, like, I'm sure he can be successful in your company. So I'm like, all right, fine. You know, let's. Let's have the conversation. I'll have the conversation. And I had, like, probably five or six conversations at least with Brennan before we mutually decided that he was going to be a good fit. And we brought him on to actually lead infrastructure. And he did that really well. And then it just became very obvious to me that he should take on more and more, and the rest is history. But the. The interesting thing there is we didn't just get Brennan from that. We actually hired a lot of people in the Seattle area that were either ex Ookla or just part of that network. And so that. That's been actually a. A pretty meaningful, like, part of. Of our company hiring has been through that.

Millie Hanson: 53:14
I mean, my question to you on the back of that is, how do you know what good talent looks like? Like, when you're looking to hire, say, an engineer? What is, like, the key thing?

Zhen Lu: 53:24
Yeah, it's that that question is becoming harder and harder to answer. I actually had a conversation today with one of my managers who was like, how do you think we need to change our hiring practices? You know, now that things are changing a lot, like, they're obviously trying to roll with the punches. The TLDR there is. I said this earlier, I'm a big believer in trajectory. I would much rather hire somebody with two years of experience that has demonstrated that they have learned a lot and grown a lot in those two years, rather than hiring somebody with 10, 20 years of experience who seems like they're just stagnant. So growth and speed of growth is really, really important to me. I did a lot of hiring previously. We had grown the team originally when I was at comcast from those eight people to almost 100 people. And I hired like personally half of those people. And what I ended up doing a lot there was really digging deep on how passionate people were in the things that, you know, things that they liked. Like it doesn't, it didn't even have to be engineering. And then I would just like see how deep they could go on the things that they were most passionate on. And what I found were the people that could dig really deep in their passions and then also prove to me that they had the aptitude and passion for what I was bringing them on to do, were actually really, really successful. One of the really, really awesome engineers that we have on our team today, his name is Zach McKenna and he actually followed me from Comcast and when I hired him at Comcast, it was his first software engineering job and he was doing sound and stage before, nothing to do with programming. And he's a rock star.

Like he, he is pushing the envelope on like multi agent development right, right now. And like the people around him that have way more experience than he has are like, how did you get here? Right? Like, you know, it doesn't make any sense. So I think that that's a big one. I think with AI I'm really thinking about like, what are the major skills you need to have? And I think it really comes down to like thirst for knowledge. Like you need to be, you need to be really like banging your face against like the, you know, like if you're, honestly, if you're not running like, and trying to orchestrate multiple cloud code instances and stuff like that, you're behind the curve at this point. I've been thinking about maybe I need to pick up speed reading because I find that I am an IO bottleneck now. And I think engineers are becoming an IO bottleneck. So how can I speak faster with good diction so that I can dictate faster to output? How do I speed read and ingest information faster? Because otherwise, like being flesh and blood, like I am the bottleneck. And if I can make myself faster at being like in, you know, the human in the loop, that actually can have really, really meaningful leverage when we're dealing with AI systems.

Millie Hanson: 56:44
Yeah, for sure. I think like Emmett is on like a similar thing. I'm not sure if you've seen, but Emmett put a post out recently and we've all got like little whisper flow mics. And then I think the hook. What was the hook? Let me just get it out.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 56:59
Codes. They voice code.

Zhen Lu: 57:00
Oh yeah, I saw that, I saw that. Yeah, I'm using whisper flow, but I'm actually vibe coding my own version because I'm not super happy with the fact that I don't have a unified, like a unified input, like for all my devices. So, you know, I've decided that my phone is the unified device that I want to be able to use. Right. So my goal is that I should be able to dictate through my phone and it should be able to hit any device that I interact with. And so I'll have like the unified experience through my phone. But anyways, I digress.

Millie Hanson: 57:45
No, that's super cool. And then kind of last question, this is kind of a light thought leadership question. Do you have any hot takes in this space? This is again like something that's a little bit funny that we can write about. Just want to know if you've come across anything.

Zhen Lu: 58:10

I think I'll just, I'll drop you like a bunch of random thoughts, whether they're useful or not. So I think number one is more infrastructure related. I don't think homogeneous clusters, even though those are the ones that are getting deployed most often, are how like AI infrastructure should be. So the people that are buying like tons of like B2 hundreds or B1 hundreds or H1 hundreds or H2 hundreds and clustering them in like homogenous ways, I think that's fine for the era of training, which I think a lot of people have decided, like it's not really a thing anymore, but not so great because our workloads, right, our varied and the shoehorn them into these giant homogeneous clusters just ain't gonna work. So there's one. So, you know, run pod. You know, we, we actually started with the philosophy that we wanted to build software that could run anywhere, everywhere, on anything we launched. When we launched on Reddit, it was number one, it was free, number two, it was on servers that I had in my basement partypad in his basement on Comcast home Internet, right? So it was like the trashiest setup that you could basically get. And we programmed it and created the platform so that it could run on stuff like that and it could run well on stuff like that. I think the other thing is that a lot of people talk about demand supply, demand imbalance and this idea that we're in a supply constrained environment and that supply constraint could be GPUs. We're playing round robin, right? It's like GPU power, it's dram, right? It's chassis. We're playing round robin. And I think what a lot of people don't realize is that it's actually a question of scale. The supply crunch really exists painfully at the really large scales. So like, if you are a supplier, like Core Weave, trying to deploy hundreds of megawatts, that's really freaking hard right now. Good luck finding places that will let you deploy right at that scale. If you are a customer that needs to create a training cluster, like if you're a meta of the world or OpenAI, right? Those kinds of companies where you need massive amounts of GPUs in a cluster in one place, let's say 100 megawatts, that's incredibly hard, right? And that's, that's why you have projects like Stargate. But if you are most companies out there, that is not the problem that you're running into. You are maybe running into or hearing about the problems that these other companies have, but that's actually not the world that a lot of companies today are living in. And I think that that's something that's not talked about as much. Right. People tend to have these blanket kind of declarations of, you know, we're in a supply crunch or not. Let's see. You know, there are these smaller things where like, you know, I think speed reading is going to be something that needs to be taught in schools.

Millie Hanson: 01:01:40
Okay, hit me with saying that a little bit more.

Zhen Lu: 01:01:44
Yeah. Because, because I think, like, I've had some conversations around, like, well, I think education is so like, at least the way that we think about it, like government's not

going to catch up fast enough. Right. So I think maybe privatization of education is inevitable. And then like, what do you learn in school? Right? Like, I think that there are the very high level answers where it's like, I think you need to learn how to learn how to pick up things very, very quickly. Right. It's not going to be about facts, memorization. It's not going to be about learning about, like, the state of things today. It's going to be learning about how do you get more information, how do you actually ingest information quickly? And so a practical skill that I think people need to get is like, really can do speed reading. It's a little bit more. Right. Because, yeah, it's not just can you read the words, it's can you ingest them? Can you pattern match? Right. And I believe that that skill is going to be incredibly important because we are going to be the slowest things. Right. Like in our world. And so our ability to incrementally make ourselves faster gonna have compounding effects. Yeah. The other thing is, which is a bit weird for me to say, is like, I think the United States actually has a leg up here because of the individualist culture that we have. Taste and ability to articulate and put yourself out there with that taste is going to be very, very important because AI is going to increasingly be autonomous and it's going to create a situation where hopefully it's the one reacting to us. But in a lot of cases, this is maybe a little bit more dystopian. Humans are going to be reacting to AI. Right. It's like push and pull. And the most successful people, I think, are the ones that are going to be able to push more than they get pulled.

Millie Hanson: 01:03:45
No, that makes complete sense. We're going to be our own bottlenecks.

Zhen Lu: 01:03:50
Anyways, I think there's some random thoughts for sure.

Millie Hanson: 01:03:53
Thank you so much for that. I think we've got a lot of good content there. And obviously for my understanding as well, it's been super helpful. I'm not sure, Emmett, if you had anything you wanted to add?

Emmett Chen-Ran: 01:04:05
No, I think it's been super interesting. We're excited to get some posts out for qa to you guys.

Zhen Lu: 01:04:11
Yeah, thanks so much for spending time with me.

Millie Hanson: 01:04:14
Amazing. Thank you so much. Enjoy. Well, enjoy your evening.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 01:04:18
Yep.

Zhen Lu: 01:04:19
Take care.

Emmett Chen-Ran: 01:04:19
Thanks.

Millie Hanson: 01:04:20
Bye.